BEN WEINTRAUT

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EDUCATION

Duke University
Ph.D. in Environmental Economics — Expected 2027
M.A. in Economics

University of Chicago
M.A. in Public Policy with Certificate in Research Methods — 2017

University of Georgia
B.A. (*summa cum laude*; Phi Beta Kappa) in Economics and Political Science — 2015

FIELDS

Energy and Environmental Economics; Household Finance; Industrial Organization; Insurance

RESEARCH

Job Market Papers

- Insurance, Endogenous Exposure, and the Welfare Cost of Disaster Risk

  Abstract: Subsidized disaster insurance presents a welfare tradeoff: it provides a risk-sharing benefit but can increase exposure to disaster risk by shifting capital toward hazardous locations. This paper develops a tractable model of capital allocation under disaster risk that characterizes the welfare implications of this tradeoff. The model shows that, at the private optimum, the wedge between the social and private marginal cost of locating capital in one location rather than another is equal to the difference in their dollar pricing gaps — the gap between charged and full-cost premiums at each location. The spatial allocation of capital is therefore socially efficient if and only if dollar pricing gaps are equal across locations. Furthermore, the welfare cost of departures from this condition can be evaluated using a sufficient statistics approximation requiring only three empirical objects, and without estimation of a full spatial equilibrium model. I apply this framework to the National Flood Insurance Program, using administrative policy-level data to evaluate the welfare consequences of the NFIP's transition from its legacy rating methodology to Risk Rating 2.0 (RR2), which applied full-risk pricing to newly issued policies beginning October 2021. For the insured stock in place immediately before RR2 took effect, I estimate annual welfare losses of approximately $19–$77 million associated with geographic differences in dollar pricing gaps under the legacy rating methodology, relative to a counterfactual of equal gaps across locations. Under RR2, I estimate approximately $42–$293 million in present-value welfare gains from the improved spatial allocation of new residential investment as charged premiums move toward modeled full-risk costs, relative to the indefinite continuation of the legacy rating methodology.

- Energy Costs and Household Financial Distress: Evidence from the Mortgage Market

  Abstract: In this paper, I estimate the effect of household energy expenditure shocks on mortgage default risk. Using loan-level mortgage servicing data and a constructed measure of temperature-driven energy expenditures, I exploit differences in the energy costs of comparable temperature shocks across locations. A one-standard-deviation increase in average monthly predicted energy expenditures over the preceding year (approximately $21 per month) raises the monthly probability of entering delinquency by roughly 14 basis points, or 10% of the baseline rate. Robustness and falsification tests provide evidence that the estimated effects operate through household energy expenditures rather than other consequences of temperature shocks, while stronger effects among borrowers with lower credit scores are consistent with a liquidity mechanism. These findings identify recurring energy costs as a source of liquidity pressure contributing to mortgage default risk, while also extending the energy affordability literature beyond expenditure burdens and consumption trade-offs to household credit outcomes.

Working Papers

- News and the Pricing of Environmental Risk (with Jaeyong Han, Paige Weber, and Christopher Timmins)
- A History of Market Concentration in the U.S. Electricity Sector
- Modeling Need in Federal Energy Assistance (with Michelle Graff)

Works in Progress

- The Price Effects of Electric Utility Mergers Under Cost-of-Service Regulation
- The Distributional Impact of Property Tax Assessment Caps

Selected Policy Publications

- "Electric Utility Mergers: Economic Evidence, Regulatory Institutions, and Consumer Protections" (co-author), *Nicholas Institute for Energy, Environment & Sustainability*, Forthcoming.
- "LIHEAP Under Heat: Assessing Policy Reforms and Funding Needs to Address State Energy Burdens" (lead author), *Nicholas Institute for Energy, Environment & Sustainability*, February 2026.
- "State-Level Heterogeneity in the Price Elasticity of Demand for Electricity in the U.S. Residential Market" (lead author), *Nicholas Institute for Energy, Environment & Sustainability*, December 2025.
- "Counting the Cost: Quantifying the Rising Impacts of Heat-Related Productivity Losses in the United States" (co-author), *Nicholas Institute for Energy, Environment & Sustainability*, September 2025.
- "Economic Report of the President (2025)" (contributor), Council of Economic Advisers, Executive Office of the President, January 2025.
- "Flooding and Finances: Hurricane Harvey's Impact on Consumer Credit" (co-author), *Chicago Fed Letter*, June 2019.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Nicholas Institute for Energy, Environment & Sustainability Durham, NC
Affiliated Researcher Jan 2025 – present

- Lead economic research projects on electricity demand, household energy affordability, and competition in the U.S. electricity sector; author policy-oriented research reports and public-facing resources.
- Presented invited expert testimony on the economics of electric utility mergers before the Virginia Energy Commission; consulted with the California Public Utilities Commission on the effects of rate increases on end-use customers.

The White House Council of Economic Advisers Washington, DC
Staff Economist Mar 2024 – Jan 2025

- Conducted economic research in support of the Executive Office of the President, with a portfolio spanning climate, energy, and industrial policy; synthesized evidence into policy memoranda and contributed to the *2025 Economic Report of the President*.
- Represented CEA in White House task forces, interagency working groups, and international policy forums, including the OECD Economic Policy Committee and Inclusive Forum on Carbon Mitigation Approaches.

Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago Chicago, IL
Associate Economist Jul 2017 – Mar 2019; May 2020 – Aug 2020

- Supported research on household finance, insurance markets, and financial stability; co-authored a *Chicago Fed Letter* examining Hurricane Harvey's impact on consumer credit.
- Produced quarterly reports assessing financial conditions in the insurance sector and potential sources of systemic risk, in collaboration with researchers at the Federal Reserve Board of Governors.

Earlier Experience: Analyst Fellow, Ithaka S+R (2019–2020); Economic Research Fellow, Jain Family Institute (2019–2020); Research Assistant, University of Chicago Urban Labs (2016–2017).

TEACHING ASSISTANTSHIPS

- ENVIRON 640: Climate Change Economics and Policy Spring 2023
- PUBPOL 811: Economics of the Public Sector Fall 2022, Spring 2023
  - ◇ Guest Lecturer — "Taxes on Labor Supply"
- PUBPOL 813: Quantitative Evaluation Methods Spring 2022
- PUBPOL 822: Advanced Applied Econometrics Fall 2021

SERVICE, LEADERSHIP & AWARDS

- Referee Service: *Journal of Environmental Economics and Management*; *Health Affairs*
- Duke University Summer Internship Fellowship 2026
- Project Manager, Duke Data+ Undergraduate Summer Research Program 2023
- Organizer, University Program in Environmental Policy Seminar Series 2021–2023
- Kenan Institute for Ethics Summer Fellowship 2023
- Duke University Summer Research Fellowship 2021, 2022

TECHNICAL SKILLS

GIS, Git, LaTeX, Python, R, SQL, Stata

REFERENCES

Robyn Meeks
Mark and Lynne Florian Associate Professor
Sanford School of Public Policy
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Brian Murray
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Christopher Timmins
Gary J. Gorman Affordable Housing Professor
Wisconsin School of Business
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Paige Weber
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